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Partly sunny 85/63 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 87/54 **B18** Democracy Dies in Darkness FRIDAY, APRIL 17, 2026 • \$4

Virginia's ex-Lt. Gov. and wife found dead

Police say Justin Fairfax killed his spouse and turned the gun on himself

BY JOE HEIM, JUAN BENN JR., GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER AND TEO ARMUS

Former Virginia lieutenant governor Justin Fairfax had been ordered to leave his family's home and lost custody of his two children in the weeks before he killed his wife, Cerina — and then himself — in their home early Thursday, according to court documents.

The onetime rising star in Virginia's Democratic Party, whose career was derailed by sexual assault allegations that he vociferously denied for years, had become increasingly isolated and was behaving erratically, records in the couple's divorce proceeding show.

"Heavy daily alcohol" use had become routine after the end of his term in 2022, and his wife told the court that he had used money meant for horseback-riding lessons for their children to purchase a gun that year.

Fairfax County Police Chief Kevin Davis said Justin Fairfax shot Cerina Wanzer Fairfax several times in the basement of their home in the Annandale area of Northern Virginia, then shot and killed himself in an upstairs bedroom.

"This has been an ongoing domestic dispute surrounding what seems to be a complicated or messy divorce," Davis said at a news conference Thursday morning outside the couple's home.

Justin Fairfax, a Democrat, was elected to Virginia's second-highest office in 2017, becoming the second African American elected statewide in Virginia. He served with then-Gov. Ralph Northam and was once a favorite to become the state's chief executive.

But the sexual assault allegations from years past brought by two women upended those hopes

SEE FAIRFAX ON A10

Political career: Fairfax's rapid rise flamed out after scandal. **A10**

In Africa, Chicago-born pope is increasingly vocal



GUGLIELMO MANGIAPANE/REUTERS

Pope Leo XIV arrives in Bamenda, Cameroon, on Thursday to celebrate Mass. Days after insults from President Donald Trump, the pontiff delivered a forceful appeal for peace and condemned what he described as "a handful of tyrants" who are ravaging the world in a speech during his 10-day trip to four countries in Africa. **Story, A12**

Judge imposes new restrictions on ballroom work

BY DAN DIAMOND AND JONATHAN EDWARDS

A federal judge set new limits on President Donald Trump's planned White House ballroom, saying construction could proceed only on an underground portion of the project deemed necessary by the military, and not on the 90,000-square-foot above-ground addition that Trump has eyed to entertain VIP guests.

"National security is not a blank check to proceed with otherwise unlawful activity," U.S. District Judge Richard Leon wrote Thursday. He said the Trump administration could also take steps to secure the construction site to make it safe for people on the

Only bunker construction may continue, he decrees, drawing Trump's scorn

White House grounds, to protect the structural integrity of the building and to shield the underground work.

Leon chastised the Trump administration for its "incredible, if not disingenuous" interpretation of his order last month to halt work on Trump's planned \$400 million project until the president obtains authorization from Congress.

The judge's original order al-

lowed the White House to do further construction to ensure "the safety and security of the White House" after officials said work on an underground emergency bunker was necessary to protect the president, his family and his staff.

Trump, who had mischaracterized Leon's earlier rulings as victories for the White House, attacked the judge Thursday on social media, calling him "a man who has gone out of his way to undermine National Security, and to make sure that this Great Gift to America gets delayed."

"No Judge can be allowed to stop this Historic and Militarily Imperative Project," the president wrote in a lengthy post on his Truth Social platform.

The president had previously argued that Leon's order allowed him to keep building the ballroom, citing his plans to add bulletproof glass, bomb shelters and other security features to the building.

"This is positive for us," Trump told reporters last month, insisting that work could continue — a claim echoed by Justice Department lawyers who swiftly appealed Leon's ruling. A three-judge panel at the U.S. Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit last week asked Leon to clarify what parts of the project were paused before it rules on the case.

Leon, an appointee of President George W. Bush, rebuffed

SEE BALLROOM ON A4

Israel, Lebanon agree to ceasefire

U.S.-BROKERED DEAL BRINGS 10-DAY PAUSE

Work goes on for new round of talks with Iran

BY SUZAN HAIDAMOUS, SUSANNAH GEORGE AND ADAM TAYLOR

BEIRUT — A tentative 10-day ceasefire was greeted with celebratory gunfire after the clocks hit midnight in Lebanon, as the U.S.-brokered deal that promised to halt Israeli strikes in the country went into force.

The ceasefire was announced early Thursday by President Donald Trump and confirmed by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. In a later video, Netanyahu said that Israel had an "opportunity to forge a historic peace agreement with Lebanon" but that Israeli forces would remain inside Lebanese territory in a "reinforced security buffer zone."

The agreement was not negotiated by Hezbollah, the group that Israel had been targeting and which gave ambiguous statements about whether they would recognize it. "A ceasefire must include a comprehensive halt to attacks across all Lebanese territory, with no freedom of movement for Israeli forces, and a return to the situation prior to March 2," when the current round of conflict between Israel and Hezbollah began, the group said in a statement.

There was a flurry of strikes ahead of the start of the ceasefire. The Israeli military said there were at least 40 strikes from Lebanon after Trump announced the pause, and Lebanese state media reported "heavy airstrikes" in several regions.

The announcement came amid a wider push in the region to end the war in Iran, as U.S. and Iranian negotiators continue to exchange messages, without yet agreeing to a second round of talks.

SEE MIDEAST ON A12

Uranium: Iran has agreed to hand over "nuclear dust," Trump says. **A6**

Kennedy defends agenda, spars with Democrats

Lawmakers challenge health secretary on vaccines, budget cuts

BY RACHEL ROUBEIN AND LAUREN WEBER

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. defended his controversial record leading the nation's health department, as Democrats argued his changes on vaccines threatened public health in America and pushed back against his proposed budget cuts.

On Thursday, Kennedy kicked off a marathon of seven congressional hearings where lawmakers grilled him for the first time in more than seven months. The hearings will continue through next week.

Kennedy's health department has recently undergone a major leadership shake-up, and he's leaned into his messaging around food and nutrition as GOP pollsters warn of the political risks of vaccine skepticism ahead of the midterms. But for hours on Thursday,

SEE HEARING ON A5



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. testified at a congressional hearing on Thursday at the Capitol that at times became combative. The hearings are scheduled to continue through next week.

Trump officially taps Schwartz to lead CDC

Overhaul of agency tests GOP, with vaccines being a key midterms issue

BY LENA H. SUN, DAN DIAMOND AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

President Donald Trump believes he has found a prescription to fix the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: a four-person team to lead an agency charged with advising Americans on navigating health challenges that has seen a precipitous decline in public trust.

Trump on Thursday named Erica Schwartz, a deputy U.S. surgeon general during his first term, as his pick to lead the agency.

"She is a STAR!" he wrote on his Truth Social platform. The role requires Senate confirmation.

The president also named Sean Slovenski, a former Wal-

mart executive, as a CDC deputy director and chief operating officer; Jennifer Shuford, an infectious-disease physician who is Texas's health commissioner, as a CDC deputy director and chief medical officer; and Sara Brenner, a senior FDA official and former acting commissioner, as senior counselor for public health.

"These Highly Respected Doctors of Medicine have the knowledge, experience, and TOP degrees to restore the GOLD STANDARD OF SCIENCE at the CDC," Trump wrote.

The Washington Post reported Tuesday that Schwartz, Slovenski, Shuford and Brenner were the White House's planned picks to lead the CDC.

Trump's latest attempt to put his stamp on the CDC comes amid questions about whether the agency will continue to implement Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s vaccine agenda or back away ahead of the midterm elections, with many voters opposed

SEE CDC ON A14

IN THE NEWS

War powers resolution The Republican-led House narrowly rejected a measure directing the president to end hostilities in Iran. **A6**

One arch? Why stop there? The president's top arts commissioner says the city needs three arches to satisfy architect Pierre L'Enfant's original vision for the capital. **A3**

THE NATION More young men are attending churches or other houses of worship at least monthly. **A2**
The president keeps his hold on Christians, but his bluster and pope fight strain the bond. **A2**

THE WORLD Japan's hawkish prime minister seeks to soften the "pacifist" clause in the constitution. **A11**
A strike by Nigeria, a U.S. ally, against Islamist militants may have killed scores. **A13**

THE ECONOMY IBM has agreed to pay \$17 million to settle Justice Department allegations that the company's DEI policies violated antidiscrimination laws. **A18**
U.S. stocks notched another record, leaping more than 10 percent since late March. **A18**

STYLE Netflix's 'Beef,' an Emmy-winning hit, is back with a second season, inspired by a real-life shouting match. **B1**

SPORTS Hockey legend Alex Ovechkin, mulling retirement, is keeping the Capitals (and his kids) guessing. **B7**

THE REGION The public has right to officers' names in police use-of-force records, a Maryland court ruled. **B13**

WEEKEND **Earth Day:** Join fellow Washingtonians to clean up parks and waterways, or learn about recycling and gardening at family-friendly festivals.

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